

Inca

At its peak from 1438 to 1532 CE, the vast Inca Empire stretched 4,000 kilometres (2,500 miles) from Peru to Chile and across to the Amazon rainforests. Incan accomplishments in civil engineering were outstanding, but because they did not write, their history remains obscure. Most of their ceremonial architecture was built to worship the sun god and his temporal representative, 'Inca'. Elements of their buildings include wall reliefs, terracing, trapezoidal openings and masks. Chan Chan was the capital of the pre-Incan kingdom of Chimor, built c.1200–1470. With reservoirs and an irrigation system, it was arranged on nine quadrangles, within which hundreds of near-identical mud brick buildings were organized. At an altitude of 2,430 metres (7,970 ft) above sea level, the granite-walled city of Machu Picchu (opposite) was built in the mid-1400s from local materials. Terraces, containing courtyards, gardens and fields, are noted for their mortar-free masonry: though extraordinarily close-fitting, the loose stone blocks permitted slight movement, which helped them survive earthquakes.

